RELS 103 Death and the Afterlife in Oaxaca, New Orleans, Varanasi & Japan | **103.01 T/R 9:25-10:40** | **103.02 T/R 10:50-12:05** | **Fall 2026** | **ECTR 219**

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Course Description

Travel is fatal to prejudice, bigotry and narrow-mindedness, and many of our people need it sorely on these accounts. Broad, wholesome, charitable views of men and things cannot be acquired by vegetating in one little corner of the earth all one's lifetime. — Mark Twain, *The Innocents Abroad*
If anything is sacred, the human body is sacred—Walt Whitman, "I Sing the Body Electric" in *Leaves of Grass*

This course is an introduction to the academic study of religion and how people from different religions and cultures have wrestled with and responded to the existential threat of death. After introducing some critical tools for studying religion, we will explore ideas and practices about death in Mexico and New Orleans, in Hindu India and among Buddhists in India and Japan. Topics to be explored include varying conceptions of the soul, consciousness, and the body, what happens at death, the role of funerary rituals, and competing views about brain death and organ transplants. After studying many fascinating beliefs and practices about the Catholic cult of the holy dead in Europe and Mexico and voodoo and jazz funerals in New Orleans, we travel to the ancient city of Varanasi in India, which is a place for Hindus to live a "good life" and to achieve a "good death." Finally, we will study Buddhist ideas about death and the liminal moments experienced in both life and death that are found in Tibetan and Japanese Buddhism. One of the fun things of this class is that we get to do some "traveling" to Mexico, New Orleans, India, and Japan through documentaries and films, which will serve as visual "texts."

The course presumes no previous background in religious studies. Students should be curious and serious, willing to read interesting materials about different religions and to engage in conversation about these readings. We will read texts that combine travel narrative, story-telling, and religious study, and watch films to gain insight into the sacred stories and rituals that relate to the landscapes of the afterlife.

Course Goals

- to gain knowledge of death and the afterlife in religions beyond your own experience
- to develop new ways of seeing what is "sacred" about death in Mexico, the US, India, & Japan
- to make what seems strange more familiar and what is familiar seem strange

Religious Studies Student Learning Outcomes

- Students acquire literacy in the key ideas and practices of different religions (see p. 13 below)
- Students demonstrate effective writing skills by crafting an argument in support of a thesis

This course satisfies a **General Education SLO** on **Global/Cultural Perspectives:** *Students demonstrate, analyze, or interpret how ideas are represented or valued in various perspectives or expressions of human culture.* Specifically, students...

- identify or frame a perspective or expression of human culture.
- analyze how the perspective or expression is represented, interpreted, or valued.
- describe the significance of the perspective or expression of human culture.

This General Education SLO will be demonstrated on the **2nd essay** due **10/22 (15%)**

Recommended & Required Books are available at Barnes & Noble CofC Bookstore or from Amazon:

* Shawn D. Haley, *Day of the Dead: When Two Worlds Meet in Oaxaca.* 2004—**recommended**
* Ann Tashi Slater, *Traveling in Bardo: The Art of Living in an Impermanent World,* 2025–**required**
* Shinmon Aoki, *Coffinman: Journal of a Buddhist Mortician*, 2002—**recommended**
* Also required are **Electronic Readings** (ER#1-27), or scholar's articles in .pdf available on OAKS, which students can access after they login to MyPortal.charleston.edu and select RELS103 "Content." Please **download and print out each article** and bring it to class on the day that it is due. You should read the assignment ***before*** we study the topic in class. This will help you understand the lectures on it. We pay close attention to these readings and "unpack" their content in class.
* **Notebook** for taking notes during class lectures & **3x5** or **5x7 notecards** for weekly Reflections (RC)

Attendance Policy & Participation in Class Discussions (10% of grade)
Attendance records will be kept for each class: there may be 3 allowed absences; 4-7 will negatively affect your grade. After 8 absences, the student will earn a failing grade (F) for excessive absences. You are responsible for making up any absences; please get any notes on missed lectures from a classmate. One form of disruption occurs when students arrive late or leave early; please don't leave in the middle of class unless you absolutely must. Prepare for each class by reading the assignment and forming questions and insights that can help us engage in meaningful discussion. You cannot participate if you are not present. Quality counts more than quantity, but you must speak up. If you are worried about participation, let's meet soon to strategize (after class or during my office hours).

Reflection Cards (RC#1-15 worth **15% of grade)**
There will be regular homework assignments. Once a week on days marked on the syllabus with **RC due** you are to bring to class a thoughtful, written reflection related to the assigned reading for that week. The reflection should be written on a **3x5 or 5x7 card** and be based on a topic or issue that you have found puzzling, thought provoking, challenging, or interesting, and **demonstrate your critical thinking skills**. A simple summary of key ideas or themes in the reading does not reflect the critical thinking expected.

Grades for RC are: + = 100; √+ = 90; √ = 80; √- = 75; — = 70.

Two short essays of 2 pages (10% each) and one of 4 pages (15%) for 35% of overall grade
Short essays will be written on the assigned reading. These essays will require that you analyze the text closely, formulate an interpretation, and express it concisely in two or four pages. The essays are due in class on the day when we will discuss the topic; late papers are not accepted since the topic will be discussed in class. Any essay assignment not turned in will receive a 0.

2 Quizzes on 9/22 & 11/17 (5% each or 10%); Midterm & Final Exam (15% each for 30%)
Quizzes and exams consist of multiple choice, short answer, and explanation of important passages excerpted from texts. Study guides will be provided beforehand. Each Quiz, Midterm and Final will be taken in class, and you can use 2 pages of handwritten notes. The Final is not comprehensive, but it deals with the material on Hinduism and Buddhism in India and Japan from the second half of the class. If you miss an exam, notify me by email prior to the exam and provide a documented excuse, I do give makeup tests, but only with documentation. An unexcused missed exam counts as a 0.

Grading Scale A = 100-93 A- = 92-90 B + = 89-87 B = 86-83 B - = 82-80 C + = 79-77
C = 76-73 C - = 72-70 D + = 69-67 D = 66-63. D - = 62-60 F = 59-below

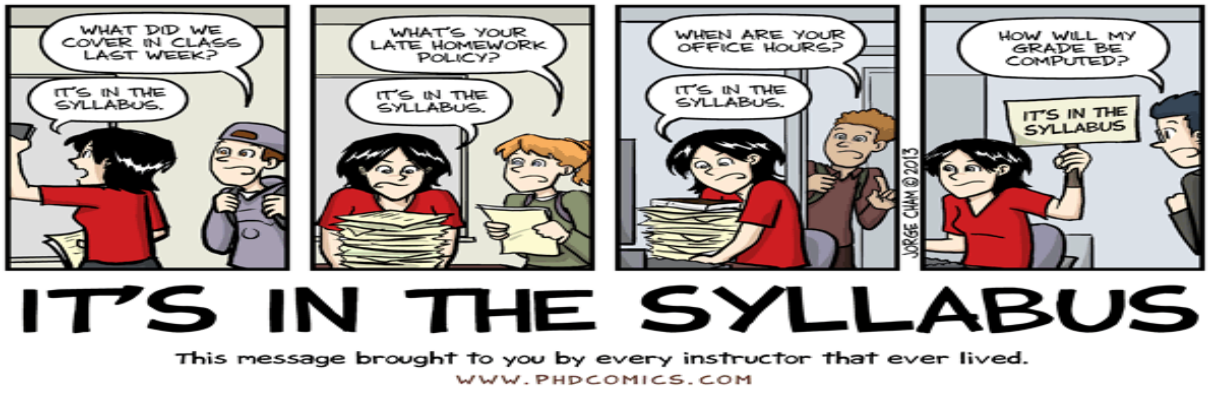
Learning Format: This is a class that meets face-to-face, not online**.** Our class will meet in ECTR 219, and it is important that you read all the required texts for each lesson, so that you will be prepared to engage in discussion. If in-person classes are suspended due to extreme weather, I will announce on OAKS and by your CofC email address a detailed plan for a change of modality to ensure continuity of learning. You must have access to a computer equipped with a camera, microphone, and internet access.

Course Resources
I encourage you to utilize the academic support services offered by the **Writing Lab** for assistance in essay writing consultation: **https://cofc.sharepoint.com/sites/hub-csl**. For more information on the **Center for Student Learning** call **843.953.5635.** Here's a link for help with writing an essay in Religious Studies: **https://writingcenter.unc.edu/tips-and-tools/religious-studies/**

Universal Learning and SNAP program
I am committed to the principle of universal learning. This means that our classroom, our virtual spaces, our practices and our interactions be as inclusive as possible. Mutual respect, civility, and the ability to listen carefully are crucial to learning. Any student eligible for or needing accommodations because of a disability should speak with me during the first two weeks of class or as soon as the student has been approved for services so that reasonable accommodations can be made. For more information on the SNAP program, contact **Center for Disability Services** **http://disabilityservices.cofc.edu** 843.953.1431

Code of Conduct for this class—the renunciation of technology
This class will be modeled on how Hindu & Buddhist monks & nuns study texts while at a monastery. There texts are not consumed on computers, tablets or cell phones, but as books printed on paper. So, leave your computers, tablets and cell phones at home and bring the assigned books or E-reading printed on pages that you can annotate in class with pencil or pen. You should also bring a notebook to class for taking notes on the lectures and jot down your thoughts and responses to our class discussions. You are strongly encouraged to put yourself on a "digital diet" and "renounce attachment" to social media.

Generative Artificial Intelligence and Academic Integrity
Intellectual honesty is vital to an academic community and for my fair evaluation of your work. Since writing and critical thinking skills are part of the learning outcomes of this course, all writing assignments submitted in this course must be your own, completed in accordance with the University's academic regulations. The use of Automated Writing Tools, including ChatGPT and other artificial intelligence tools (GAI), is strictly prohibited in this course and will be considered a violation of Academic Integrity as outlined in the **CofC Honor Code** (https://charleston.edu/policy/documents/12.4.1.pdf). Where I detect possible use of such tools, I will arrange to meet so you can explain the writing process that generated your work. Lying, cheating, and plagiarism are also violations of our Honor Code that, when suspected, are investigated. Each incident will be examined to determine the degree of deception in involved. A student found responsible by the Honor Board for academic dishonesty will receive a **XF grade** in the course, indicating failure of the course due to academic dishonesty.



Lecture Topics and Reading Schedule

The dates below provide the topic of the day, the required reading (in parentheses), and when assignments are due. Selections from *Day of the Dead, Traveling in Bardo* and *Coffinman* list the chapters and/or page numbers; selections from E-Readings (ER) on OAKS are numbered sequentially in the syllabus and on OAKS. When you access the ER readings online, you might find that the first page lists an ER# that is different from what is listed here on the syllabus or on OAKS; **trust this syllabus & OAKS ER#, not what appears on 1st page of the ER reading!**

What is Religion? Theorizing Religion and Death

8/18 Organization of Course and Introduction to the Academic Study of Religion
(Review this syllabus and course requirements in class)

8/20 Ways of Exploring Religion: Who are the *Nacirema*?
(ER #1-2: "Thinking about Being a Student of Religion" & "Body Ritual Among the Nacirema")
RC#1 due -- First Reflection Card due in class

8/25 The Social Construction of Reality; *The Truman Show* as Meaningful Myth
(ER#3-4: "How Society Works: Classification;" "The Meaning of *The Truman Show*")
Clips from *The Truman Show* (1998) shown in class

8/27 How Religion Works: Legitimation and the Afterlife
(ER#5-5A: "How Religion Works: Legitimation" & "On death/afterlife as legitimation") **RC#2**

9/1 Death as a Rite of Passage and Its Social Impact
(ER#6-7: "Liminality and Communitas" and "The Liminal Space Between Life & Death")

9/3 Bringing Religion to its Senses: What is this Religious "Stuff?"
(ER#8: "1/2" and "Soul") **RC#3 due**

The Catholic Cult of the Dead

"*Christianity is a cult of the dead. And the story of its obsession with martyrdom and the remains of the dead begin with the cross. The cross has been an instantly recognizable symbol for centuries, but what is often forgotten is how this tool of Roman torture became more than a reminder of a single event in the past. It was a model for imitation again and again. According to early Christian tradition, all but one of Jesus's faithful apostles were martyred…. The centrality of martyrdom in Christianity has profoundly affected the development of its cultural expression and literature—even its conception of time."* Kyle Smith, *Cult of the Dead: A Brief History of Christianity*

9/8 The Christian Cult of the Dead: The Death of Jesus as a Model for Martyrs
(ER#9: "Introduction" and "The First of the Dead")

9/10 The Holy Bodies of Saints: Relics as Sacred but also Bones of Contention
(ER#10: "In the Beginning Was the Tongue" and "Catch a Martyr by the Toe") **RC#4 due**

The Day of the Dead: Catholic-Indigenous Religious Syncretism in Mexico

"*For most Mesoamerican peoples, including the Zapotec of central Oaxaca, there is a very fine line that separates the world of the living from the supernatural world where the dead live. On Diá de Muertos (Day of the Dead), that line dissolves and, for a time, there is only one world. At that time, November 1st and 2nd, the dead return to their former homes on earth for a while to eat, to drink, to sing, to be entertained, and to visit w/ their loved ones. The dead return home as they have done for millennia and the living throw open their doors to them. The reunion is indeed joyous and is a time that is eagerly anticipated."* Shawn Haley, *Day of the Dead: When Two Worlds Meet*

9/15 Celebrating Life & Death in Mexico: Introducing the Day of the Dead (*Dia de Los Muertos*)
(ER#11: Chapters 1-3 in *Day of the Dead* pp. 1-6; 12-35) **RC#5 due**
Film clips from *Coco,* pt. I

9/17 Rituals of Remembrance & Sacred Sensuality During the Day of the Dead Clips from *Coco* pt. II
(ER#12: Chapters 5-8 in *Day of the Dead* pp. 69-81; 86-89; 98-99; 112-115; 123-138)

9/18 Essay#1 due on OAKS by 11:59 pm

Jazz Funerals in New Orleans: Catholic-African Diasporic Religious Syncretism

"*Most funeral traditions in our society are there to remind us that we are dust, and to dust we shall return. In New Orleans the funerals remind us that Life is bigger than any individual life, and it will roll on, and for the short time that your individual life joins the big stream of Life, cut some decent steps, for God's sake. No individual life lasts forever, and it is the responsibility of those left outside the yards of the boneyard to keep life going. This isn't escapism or denial of grief; it is acceptance of the facts of life, the map of a profound relationship to the grief that is a part of life…. It is a way of containing the opposites that are a part of life in a way that allows the individual, and the community, to function with style and grace, even wit, under the most adverse circumstances.*" Tom Piazza, *Why New Orleans Matters,* pp. 31-32.

9/22 New Orleans: City that Celebrates the Undead
(ER#13: "The City that Dreams" and "A Crypt of the Supernatural") **Quiz#1 in class**

9/24 African Diasporic Religions, Voodoo and Catholicism in New Orleans (NOLA)
(ER#14: "Follow the Second Line" & "Interlude") **RC#6 due** Film on Voodoo in NOLA

9/29 New Orleans Jazz Funerals: Blending Catholicism and African Diasporic Religions
(ER#15: "In Rhythm with the Spirit") **RC#7 due**

10/1 **Midterm Exam in class** (Review Study Guide, prepare two pages of handwritten notes)

Varanasi, Luminous City of Life & Death

"*This was Varanasi, the fabled City of Light: its scriptural name 'Kashi' means, literally, 'luminous' in Sanskrit. Certainly, it was dazzling, but to my eyes it was more like a kaleidoscope: full of symmetry and color, but also operating on the principle of multiple reflection. Everything I saw cast perspective on something else, almost every viewpoint I heard could be countered or, at the least, seen as incomprehensible by someone a few streets away. As I explored, certain themes of the city — the interplay between life & death, the industries of silk-weaving & sweet-making, the drama and music that make Varanasi both a stage and a soundtrack, a human city as well as divine — began to emerge."* — Piers Moore Ede, *Kaleidoscope City: A Year in Varanasi*

10/6 Introducing Hinduism in India and the City of Varanasi
(ER#16-17: "Introduction: Varanasi" and "Karma & Moksha at the End of Life in Hinduism")

10/8 Seeing Varanasi Through a Kaleidoscope: Western vs. Hindu Views of the City
(ER#18-19: Kaleidoscope City, "Introduction" and "Banaras: An Introduction") **RC#8 due**

10/13 **Fall Break**

10/15 Varanasi as a Sacred City Blessed by the Goddess, the Ganges River
(ER#20: "The Ganga" **RC#9 due** Documentary film: *Ganges: River to Heaven*

10/20 Varanasi as City of the Good Life
(ER#21: "City of the Good Life") Documentary film: *Beyond*

10/22 Varanasi as City of Death and Instant Moksha
(ER#22-23: "Instant Moksha" and "Good Death and the Dying Process")
Essay#2 due: As we've learned from reading about Varanasi and watching *Ganges: River to Heaven*, dying a good death is as important as living a good life for the Hindus who live there. Yet there are conflicting ideas about what "liberation" means in Varanasi. *Drawing upon "Ganges: River to Heaven" and ER#20-23, describe what makes a "good life" and a "good death" for Hindus. How does living and dying in Varanasi both uphold and undermine Hindu morality, belief in karma, and family bonds*?

Hindu of the Dom Caste Cremating a Body next to the Ganges River, Varanasi

Buddhist Teachings on Impermanence, Death and the Afterlife

"*From the summit of the highest heavens to the very depths of hell, there is not a single being who can escape death…. Everything that is born is bound to die. Nobody has ever seen anyone or heard of anyone in any realm—even in the realm of the gods—who was born but never died…. Life can only get shorter, never longer. Inexorably, Death closes in, never pausing for an instant, like the shadow of a mountain at sunset. Do you know for sure when you will die, or where? Might it be tomorrow, or tonight? Can you be sure that you are not going to die right now, between this breath and the next? As Nagarjuna says: 'Life flickers in the flurries of a thousand ills, more fragile than a bubble in a stream. In sleep, each breath departs and is again drawn in; how wondrous that we wake up living still!*" Patrul Rinpoche, *Words of My Perfect Teacher*

10/27 Buddhist Views of Death and the Geography of the Afterlife
(ER#24: Excerpts from *Words of My Perfect Teacher* on Death & Suffering in Samsara**)**

10/29 Introducing the Tibetan Book of the Dead
(*Traveling in Bardo*: Prologue, Chapters 1-2) **RC#10 due**

11/3 **No Class—do your Dharma as an American citizen and vote!**

11/5 The Visionary Geography of the Bardo in Text and Film
(*Traveling in Bardo*: Chapter 3) **RC#11 due**
Film: *The Tibetan Book of the Dead* narrated by Leonard Cohen

11/10 Taking Bardo By the Forelock
(*Traveling in Bardo,* Chapters 5-6, pp. 109-161) **RC#12 due**

11/12 Bardo Journeys and Wisdom Gained in Japan
(*Traveling in Bardo,* Chapters 7-8) **Essay#3 (or UnEssay) due in class**

Technology's Impact on Death and Religion in Japan Today

"Even when the body is dead, the soul remains in each organ of the body for quite a while, so in brain death, when the body is still warm, I don't find it possible to think about taking organs out. Anyway, I don't think we really understand what is going on in the brain at death, and a death that can only be understood by a doctor isn't death as far as I am concerned. The distance between doctors and patients is growing greater because of technology, and I think this causes a lot of distrust." Noda Junko in *Twice Dead: Organ Transplants and the Reinvention of Death*

11/17 Japanese Debates Over Brain Death and Organ Transplants: The Reinvention of Death
(ER#25: "Preamble to *Twice Dead*" and "Social Death and Situated Departures") **Quiz#2**

11/19 Buddhist Rites to Memorialize the Spirits of Fetuses
(ER#26-27: Indebtedness and Comfort" and "The Cult of Jizo: Abortion Practices in Japan and What They Can Teach Us in the West") **RC#13 due**

11/24 The Ritual Purification of Death
(*Coffinman*, chapter 1: "The Season of Sleet") Film: *Departures,* pt I

11/26 **Thanksgiving Holiday**—Eat Turkey (or Tofurkey) and Give Thanks

12/1 Remembering the Dead, Learning to Love, Feeling Filial
(*Coffinman*, chapter 2: "What Dying Means") **RC#15 due** Film: *Departures,* pt II

12/3 RELS 103.02 Final Exam on Thursday from 10:30-12:30 pm in ECTR 219

12/8 RELS 103.01 Final Exam on Tuesday from 10:30-12:30 pm in ECTR 219

Brahmin boy studying and memorizing Hindu scriptures

Sources for E-Readings (ER#1-27) on OAKS

Please use this information when you cite these sources for any of the three essays.

1. Gary E. Kessler, "Thinking about Being a Student of Religion" from *Studying Religion*, 3rd edition. Boston: McGraw Hill, 2008, pp. 1-13.
2. Horace Miner, "Body Rituals Among the Nacirema," in *The Insider/Outsider Problem in the Study of Religion*, ed. by Russell McCutcheon (London: Cassell, 1999), pp. 23-27.
3. Craig Martin, "Preface" and "How Society Works: Classification" from his *A Critical Introduction to the Study of Religion*. New York: Routledge, 2012, pp. xi-xiii; 19-44.
4. Ken Sanes, "The Meaning of *The Truman Show*" 6 pp. Used with the author's permission from http://www.transparencynow.com/truman.html
5. Craig Martin, "How Religion Works: Legitimation" from his *A Critical Introduction to the Study of Religion*. New York: Routledge, 2012, pp. 93-116.

5a. Patrul Rinpoche, excerpts from *Words of My Perfect Teacher.* Boston: Shambhala, 2008, pp. 116-117.

6. Victor Turner, "Liminality and Communitas" from *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* excerpted in *Theory and Method in the Study of Religion*, ed. by Carl Olson, pp. 268-276.
7. Hubert J. M. Hermans, "The Liminal Space Between Life & Death" in *Unprepared for Death: The Psychological Richness of Mortality.* Palgrave Macmillan, 2026, pp. 55-71.
8. S. Brent Plate, "1/2" and "Soul" from *A History of Religion in 5 ½ Objects: Bringing the Spiritual to Its Senses*. Boston: Beacon Press, 2014, pp. 1-22; 215-224.
9. Kyle Smith, "Introduction" and "First of the Dead" from *Cult of the Dead: A Brief History of Christianity.* Berkeley: University of California Press, October 2024, pp. 1-37.
10. Peter Manseau, "Prologue: In the Beginning Was the Tongue" and "Catch a Martyr By the Toe" from *Rag and Bone: A Journey Among the World's Holy Dead.* New York: Henry Holt, 2009, pp. 1-52.
11. Shawn D. Haley, chapters 1-3 of *Day of the Dead: When Two Worlds Meet in Oaxaca.* Berghan Books, 2004, pp. 1-6; 12-35.
12. Shawn D. Haley, chapters 5-8 excerpts from *Day of the Dead* pp. 69-81; 86-89; 98-99; 112-115; 123-138.
13. Robin Roberts, "The City that Dreams" and "A Crypt of the Supernatural" from *City of the Undead: Voodoo, Ghosts, and Vampires of New Orleans.* Baton Rouge, LSU Press, 2023, pp. 1-3; 10-33.
14. Richard Turner, "Follow the Second Line" and "Interlude" from *Jazz Religion, the Second Line, and Black New Orleans,* 2nd edition. Bloomington: University of Indiana Press, 2017, pp 1-11; 18-28; 69-76.
15. Richard Turner, "In Rhythm with the Spirit" from *Jazz Religion, the Second Line, and Black New Orleans*, 2nd edition. Bloomington: University of Indiana Press, 2017, pp. 97-105; 112-117; 126-33.
16. David R. Kinsley, *Hinduism: A Cultural* Perspective 2nd Edition. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice Hall, 1993, pp. 2-10.
17. Joris Gielen and Komal Kashyap, "Belief in Karma and Moksha at the End of Life in India" from *Death Across Cultures* ed. by H. Selin, R. M. Rakoff. Place of publication, publisher, pp. 19-29.
18. Piers Moore Edes, "Introduction" to ***Kaleidoscope City: A Year in Varanasi***. New York, Bloomsbury, 2015, pp. 1-8.
19. Diana Eck, "Banaras: An Introduction" in ***Banaras: City of Light.*** Columbia Univ. Press, 1999, pp. 3-27.
20. Piers Moore Edes, "The Ganga" in *Kaleidoscope City: A Year in Varanasi,* pp. 97-119.
21. Diana Eck, "City of the Good Life" in *Banaras: City of Light*, pp. 304-323.
22. Piers Moore Edes, "Instant Moksha" in *Kaleidoscope City: A Year in Varanasi,* pp. 9-29.
23. Christopher Justice, "Good Death and the Dying Process" from his *Dying the Good Death: The Pilgrimage to Die in India's Holy City*. Albany: SUNY Press, 1997, pp. 219-233.
24. Patrul Rinpoche, "Excerpts on Impermanence and Samsara" from *Words of My Perfect Teacher.* Boston: Shambhala, 2008, pp. xxxi-xxxii; 41-42; 53-54; 61-85.
25. Margaret Lock, "Preamble: Accidental Death" and "Social Death and Situated Departure" from *Twice Dead: Organ Transplants and the Reinvention of Death.* Berkeley: UC Press, 2002, pp. 1-13, 191-207.
26. Hoshino Eiki and Takeda Dosho, "Indebtedness and Comfort: The Undercurrents of *Mizuko Kuyo* in Contemporary Japan," *Japanese Journal of Religious Studies* 14/4, pp. 305-320.
27. William LaFleur, "The Cult of Jizo: Abortion Practices in Japan and What They Can Teach the West," in *Tricycle: The Buddhist Review* IV.4 (Summer 1995), pp. 41-44.
28. Shinmon Aoki, Chapters 1-2 from *Coffinman: Diary of a Buddhist Mortician,* 2002, pp. 1-

About Me...

I grew up on the west coast in beautiful Santa Barbara California, went to Reed College in Portland Oregon (where I majored in religion), earned a MA degree in religious studies at UC Santa Barbara, before I moved to Ann Arbor Michigan to pursue degrees in Buddhist Studies (I have a PhD in B.S.!). Since graduating from college, I have spent many years living in Buddhist monasteries and traveling throughout India, especially in the Himalayas of North India. I joined the Department of Religious Studies at CofC in 1999, when I was hired to teach courses in Asian religions (Religion and Society in India and Tibet, Buddhist and Hindu Traditions, Religions of China and Japan, Sacred Texts of the East, Tibetan Buddhism). But I also teach thematic courses like this one on "Death and the Afterlife," "Religion and Globalization," and "Religion and Violence." Over the past fifteen years I have led CofC students to Northern India to study how the religions of Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam and Sikhism are adapting to modernity and globalization. When not at work, I enjoy watching sports (especially CofC basketball games—Go Cougs!), biking, kayaking, and hiking in the mountains, and going on long road trips in the South, in the Pacific Northwest and western Canada.

Learning about different religions should be an intellectual adventure that engages the imagination, and I have chosen reading material and films that I hope you will find fascinating. I expect students to come prepared and make meaningful contributions to our class discussions. If you are experiencing challenges that make it difficult for you to do so, I encourage you to meet with me privately so that we can work together to develop a solution.

Introducing CofC students to the Buddhist Wheel of Life/Death/Rebirth in Ladakh, North India, 2016